

The Future of Crowd Work, 13 years later

In 2013, a paper born at CrowdCamp asked: *“Can we foresee a future crowd workplace in which we would want our children to participate?”* It set out twelve research areas. Help us score them.

- 1 Take one dot for each sheet.
- 2 On each sheet, put your dot in the zone that fits best: *Happened*, *AI changed it* or *Still open*.
- 3 Add a sticky note if you want to say why, or name what’s missing on the last sheet.

WORK PROCESS

1. Workflow
2. Task assignment
3. Hierarchy
4. Real-time response
5. Synchronous collaboration
6. Quality control

COMPUTATION

7. Crowds guiding AIs
8. AIs guiding crowds
9. Platforms

WORKERS

10. Job design
11. Reputation and credentials
12. Motivation and rewards

NEW IN 2026

13. Governance and the social contract

“Hybrid combinations of workers and artificial intelligence that seek to build collective intelligence may instead lead to mechanized workers or human-imitating machines.”

Kittur et al., The Future of Crowd Work, CSCW 2013

Workflow

2013 VISION

Break complex work into subtasks, manage the dependencies between them, and assemble the results.

2026 QUESTION

One person with agentic AI now matches a hackathon team of five. Do we still need to decompose work across people?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Task assignment

2013 VISION

Match workers to tasks that fit their skills and interests, so requesters get speed and workers stay steadily employed.

2026 QUESTION

When agents take most tasks, what is left to assign to people, and who decides?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Hierarchy

2013 VISION

Crowd teams with managers and reviewers, so groups can take on large, complex work.

2026 QUESTION

Who manages whom when a team includes agents?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Real-time response

2013 VISION

Crowds on call that respond within seconds for work that cannot wait.

2026 QUESTION

Models answer instantly. When do we still need people on call?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Synchronous collaboration

2013 VISION

Strangers build rapport fast enough to work together on a task within an hour.

2026 QUESTION

If one person with AI can do a team's work, why do we still work together?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Quality control

2013 VISION

Keep work quality high, including for open-ended and expert tasks where no gold standard exists.

2026 QUESTION

Who catches the AI's failures, and how do teams agree on how far to trust its output?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Crowds guiding AIs

2013 VISION

People do the work AI systems cannot yet do. The paper warned that workers “may end up training machines to replace them.”

2026 QUESTION

Did they? And who now holds the harness when AI fails, bug-bounty style?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Als guiding crowds

2013 VISION

Software steers crowd work, catching errors before they spread through the crowd.

2026 QUESTION

AI now leads much of the work. Where do people still steer?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Platforms

2013 VISION

New platforms that reshape the relationship between workers and requesters.

2026 QUESTION

Labs and model providers are the new platforms.
What do workers get from them?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Job design

2013 VISION

Work that builds skills and meaning, well beyond dull piecework dressed up as a game.

2026 QUESTION

What work next to AI would we be proud to see our children do?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Reputation and credentials

2013 VISION

Lasting, portable reputation, like references and work histories in traditional firms.

2026 QUESTION

How do you build a track record when an AI did half the work?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Motivation and rewards

2013 VISION

Rewards matched to workers' diverse motives and ambitions, beyond small payments per task.

2026 QUESTION

What should overseeing AI pay, and what happens when tokens cost what they really cost?

HAPPENED

It came true, more or less

AI CHANGED IT

AI reshaped or replaced it

STILL OPEN

Unsolved and it still matters

Governance and the social contract

2013 VISION

Missing from the 2013 framework. Proposed at this CrowdCamp: a social contract between people, technology and the environment, and collective action as a counterweight to AI.

2026 QUESTION

Who writes that contract? Can crowds organize the way labor unions once did?

PUT IT ON THE AGENDA

HCOMP + CI should take this on

COVERED ALREADY

Other work handles it

NOT OUR FIELD

Leave it to others

What's missing?

Which research area should the next thirteen years of HCOMP and CI take on? Write one per sticky note.

STICKY NOTES HERE

One idea per note